

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

Grades 6–8

GRADES 6–8

45 MINUTES

RESEARCH + CRITICAL ANALYSIS

SESSION GOALS

Students will: conduct targeted research using library resources and the exhibition; evaluate and compare primary and secondary sources; develop and defend an interpretive claim about the Harlem Renaissance; and practise evidence-based writing. Librarian connects information literacy skills explicitly to the historical inquiry.

PREPARATION

- Pull and display: 10–12 library books across biography, poetry collections, history, and critical essays (see page 2)
- Set up 3 research stations with specific books and a guiding question card at each (optional — see station suggestions below)
- Tables set: differentiated activity cards, pencils; computers/iPads available for Red-level independent research
- Project: one Douglas image for reference during the session

SESSION FLOW

0–5 min	Opening Provocation: Show two images side by side — Aaron Douglas's <i>Song of the Towers</i> and the Obelisk/Reconstruction mural. No labels. Ask: <i>"What is different about these two paintings — and what does the difference tell you?"</i> Take 4–5 responses. Then: <i>"Both were made by the same man, in the same decade, in Harlem. Today you're going to figure out why they look so different."</i>
5–10 min	Research Skills Frame: Briefly introduce the session structure. Model: how to use an index efficiently; what a primary source vs secondary source looks like; how to take a note without copying word-for-word. Remind: <i>"Your job is not to collect facts. Your job is to build an argument."</i>
10–38 min	Research and Activity Cards: Students work on differentiated cards, using library resources. Red-level students have independent research tasks requiring catalogue use. Circulate: challenge students to show you one piece of evidence and explain how it supports their argument. Push for analytical writing, not summary.
38–45 min	Share and Synthesis: One Yellow student and one Red student share their argument/claim. Class responds: <i>"Do you agree? What evidence would you add or challenge?"</i> Close with: <i>"Everything you found today was already in this building. The library is the archive of human thought — and the Harlem Renaissance is part of that archive."</i>



Mini Museum Connection

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual Visit:** minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

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BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS — GRADES 6–8

History and Biography

- *The Warmth of Other Suns* — Isabel Wilkerson — the definitive Great Migration account; excerpts suitable for Gr 7–8
- *Up From Slavery* — Booker T. Washington — important context; free online
- *The Souls of Black Folk* — W.E.B. Du Bois — foundational text; excerpts appropriate for advanced Gr 8
- *Harlem Stomp!* — Laban Carrick Hill — age-appropriate history with primary source excerpts
- *Zora Neale Hurston: A Life in Letters* — edited by Carla Kaplan — primary sources

Poetry and Literature

- *The Collected Poems of Langston Hughes* — complete; ideal for class copies
- *Their Eyes Were Watching God* — Zora Neale Hurston — Gr 8+ excerpt-level; full novel for strong readers
- *The New Negro* — ed. Alain Locke (1925) — the defining anthology of the Renaissance; free online via HathiTrust
- *If We Must Die: The Life of Claude McKay* — Gary Edward Holcomb
- Poetry Foundation (poets.org): all Renaissance-era poetry free, with teaching notes

OPTIONAL RESEARCH STATION CARDS

Station A — The Poets: Find two poems by different Harlem Renaissance poets. What do they have in common? What is different about their voices and arguments?

Station B — The Painters: Research Aaron Douglas and Jacob Lawrence. Both used bold, flat shapes. How are their styles different? What was each trying to say?

Station C — The Context: Find one fact about what life was like for Black Americans in the South before the Great Migration. Find one fact about what they found in the North. Does the data change your understanding of the Harlem Renaissance?

INFORMATION LITERACY CONNECTIONS

- **Database vs book:** Show students how Britannica School or JSTOR Kids yields different results from a library book — different types of sources for different tasks
- **Citation:** Red-level students should cite at least one source in their response — introduce MLA or Chicago author-date as appropriate for grade level
- **Search strategy:** Teach subject heading searching in the catalogue: "Harlem Renaissance," "African American art — 20th century," "Jazz — history and criticism"